

■ By Ambreesh Mishra

Bellary's mining magnates hogged the headlines during the recent Karnataka polls for their successful foray into politics. In Madhya Pradesh though, the script reads out in reverse. Here, politicians have joined the gold rush and acquired vast interests in mining across the state. The consequences of this mad scramble for a piece of the mining pie have been disastrous for the environment. So bad was the condition that the state high court had to step in to bring this gravy train to a halt. In a landmark order on July 2, the green bench comprising Chief Justice A.K. Patnaik and Justice Sanjay Yadav ordered the closure of 1,732 mines across the state for running without the consent of the Madhya Pradesh Pollution Control Board (MPPCB). The sector currently employs nearly three lakh labourers and boasts of an investment to the tune of hundreds of crore of rupees.

Two government agencies admitted before the high court that hundreds of mines of various minerals had been running illegally in the state. The affidavits and other documents filed by them display the humongous extent of the unfolding disaster. That the MPPCB and Mining and Mineral Resources Department had ignored large-scale violation of environmental norms is obvious. Many water bodies around the Sehora block of Katni district near Jabalpur—one of the biggest sites for bauxite, limestone and marble mining—have shown signs of large-scale silting causing ecological damage to aquatic life.

"The surface and ground water near bauxite mines in Katni has high quantities of heavy metals like cadmium and lead that can fatally damage the human organs. The water sources around limestone mines have high concentrations of arsenic, a carcinogen," says an officer of MPPCB. The slow death of local flora in the area is all too evident since dust from mining sites interferes with photosynthesis, a process critical to a tree's health.

Despite such damning incidents, the mining department and the MPPCB have not been able to work in consonance. Even their replies to the high

Digging Towards Di

Violations of environmental laws by miners and government agencies alike have brought the state to the brink of destruction



LAWS OF NATURE

■ Obtaining the no-objection certificate is mandatory under the Centre's Environmental Impact Assessment notification of 1994

for mining major minerals.

■ Under the Central Air (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1981 as well as the Water Act of 1974, the



court reflect this. According to the MPPCB affidavit, there are 2,697 mines, including 391 of major minerals, running without consent. But the figure furnished by the mining department is much less. In its submission before the court, the MPPCB cut a sorry figure, pleading that mere issuance of closure notices to mines was hardly sufficient. The organisation even passed the buck to the mining department, stating in the affidavit that the department was in a better position to check violation. Says MPPCB Chairman Dr S.P. Gautam, "We can only issue closure notices. Under the Air and Water

Acts, we have powers to cut off electricity and water supply. But if mining operations are manual, such measures don't work. In such cases, the mining department should cancel the lease."

Many clues indicate at a multi-agency failure in preventing the loss to environment due to violation of norms. A CAG report reveals how forest land was diverted without Central clearance even to Central PSUs like Western Coalfields Ltd and South Eastern Coalfields Ltd, apart from a host of private agencies. The guilty agencies included Madhya Pradesh State Mining Corporation, a state PSU and Maihar